

South Sudan Conflict Analysis

MAIN ACTORS

Political elites and security forces	Internal divisions, political polarization, and military weaknesses deepening institutional fragility, despite ongoing offensives and external support.
SPLM-IO	Internal divisions and continued fighting undermining power-sharing agreements and contributing to sustained instability.
National Salvation Front (NAS)	Rejection of peace agreements driving continued armed activity, posing severe threat to civilians and the peace process.
Communal militias	Persistent inter-communal violence along ethnic and clan lines driving cattle raiding and land disputes, at times supported by national elites.
Dinka, Equatorian, and other ethnic communities	Perceived Dinka dominance and Equatorian marginalization intensifying competition over land and political representation, at times driving aspirations for secession and active resistance.

REGIONS WITH STRONG PEACEBUILDING CAPACITY

CENTRAL EQUATORIA

Leads on health reflecting capital-city healthcare concentration. Its lower food security score likely reflects the presence of large IDP populations in Juba.

WESTERN BAHR EL GHAZAL

Stands out for very low conflict intensity, described as one of South Sudan's most politically stable states. This stability environment may have an enabling effect on better functioning public services. However, food security score likely understates actual stress.

SEPI RANKINGS — STRONG PEACEBUILDING CAPACITY

#	Region	SEPI	Education	Health	Food Security	Poverty Reduction	Climate	Events /100k
1	Western Equatoria	0.651	0.686	0.511	1.000	0.955	0.349	21
2	Eastern Equatoria	0.585	0.549	0.417	0.538	0.774	0.720	10
3	Western Bahr el Ghazal	0.572	0.628	0.675	0.615	0.702	0.333	5
4	Central Equatoria	0.528	0.577	0.764	0.333	0.720	0.386	17

UNITY

A severe outlier, having the lowest food security score in the country. Despite holding South Sudan's oil wealth, Unity's poverty reduction score and overall SEPI signal that oil revenue is not reaching the population's welfare.

JONGLEI

Health collapse is the starkest single-pillar finding in South Sudan: the lowest health pillar score. Active military confrontation since late 2025 has damaged, looted, and shut down health facilities. 1.35 million people have lost access to health services. 73,000 face starvation in Jonglei and Upper Nile combined (March 2026 data).

UPPER NILE

Has a very low poverty reduction pillar score despite Paloch oilfields. This suggests oil production revenue does not translate to local welfare indicators, consistent with IDP numbers and conflict over resource control rather than development.

SEPI RANKINGS — WEAK PEACEBUILDING CAPACITY

#	Region	SEPI	Education	Health	Food Security	Poverty Reduction	Climate	Events /100k
10	Unity	0.095	0.414	0.228	0.000	0.321	0.250	11
9	Jonglei	0.205	0.374	0.034	0.205	0.413	0.336	19
8	Lakes	0.215	0.278	0.049	0.410	0.371	0.220	11
7	Upper Nile	0.245	0.436	0.394	0.103	0.091	0.554	12
6	Northern Bahr el Ghazal	0.334	0.394	0.499	0.256	0.461	0.179	1

SOURCES OF RESILIENCE

The R-ARCSS peace agreement of 2018 produced a measurable decline in violence and enabled the formation of a unity government in 2020.

Traditional inter-communal mediation systems have historically limited escalation in some areas such as Lakes State but have been progressively undermined by elite capture of local administration, weapons proliferation, and the erosion of justice mechanisms.

Civil society and faith-based organizations remain active despite shrinking civic space, with community peacebuilding groups across multiple states continuing to facilitate local dialogue and mitigate conflict as demonstrated in Central Equatoria as recently as 2024.